danger of becoming chairman of a largely moribund committee. On 13 August, after a long speech recounting his many numerous qualifications, Curzon threatened to resign as chair if the committee decided to reduce its remit, as was being suggested.[27] In the end, it was only when Curzon was made acting foreign secretary in January 1919 that Cecil was finally able to dissolve the Eastern Committee to be replaced by the ad hoc Interdepartmental Conference on the Middle East (IDCE).[28] In the meantime, on 28 August 1918, Eyre Crowe was appointed head of the new Middle Eastern Department of the Foreign Office, although it was agreed that he would share his authority with Hirtzel at the India Office. The Indian government would retain its political authority in Mesopotamia and Persia, while military issues were still to be referred to the War Office. The end result was that, rather than an all-encompassing body with full control over every aspect of British policy in the Middle East and Asia (as Cecil had originally envisaged), the new department was much the same as the old Eastern Department of the Foreign Office, which had been dismantled before the war.[29] The machinery for making policy in this region would continue to be muddled, leading to a lack of coherence in this period.[30] Indeed, wrangling over who was to have authority over this area of Britain's foreign policy was to continue until 1921, when another Middle Eastern Department would be created, this time under the remit of the Colonial Office.[31] In the meantime, Britain would continue to have 'two voices' (and sometimes three or four) in Persia and elsewhere in southern Asia in the immediate post-war years.

Good Red Herring

This problem of coordination would not only continue to cause friction between the Foreign, War and India Offices, but would also allow Curzon to have a resounding say over Britain's relations towards countries such as Persia in this period. For, as will be seen, with nobody to mount an effective challenge against his apparent authority on Asian affairs, Curzon would find himself able to convince others within the government that his way was ultimately the right way. As already shown, Curzon's determination to change Britain's relations with Persia had had a long gestation, and with his